
Strategic Plan 2021-2025

A summary of how Nutri-Aid Trust plans to strengthen agro-dealers, rural enterprises and the farming communities they serve.

Why we work

Agriculture is the mainstay of rural livelihoods in Zambia, yet affordable, quality inputs are often far from the farm. Smallholders travel long distances for supplies, which holds back intensification and diversification into higher-income crops.

Quality improved seed is one of the greatest constraints. Most farmers rely on informal seed, often recycled grain from the last harvest, and yields stay low. Our answer is to build the input supply chain and train rural entrepreneurs to run input supply as a business.

Who we work with

- **Agro-dealers and rural SMEs.** Rural entrepreneurs, often lead farmers themselves, who receive business skills training so farmers can get inputs close to home.
 - **Smallholder farmers.** Families farming less than five hectares with mainly family labour, who are often food insecure.
 - **Female farmers.** Women do most of the farming, so demand-creation activities such as seed fairs, field days and demonstration plots are held close to communities to enable their full participation.
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How we measure success

- Rural input retailers serving many local smallholders, especially women.
 - More affordable, timely and varied inputs and services reaching farmers.
 - Higher farmer yields and better household nutrition.
 - Higher agricultural incomes in rural areas.
 - A stronger enabling environment for agro-input networks in Zambia.
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Strategic directions

1. Agro-dealer and rural SME development

Filling the gap between lead input firms and the farmers who use their products, so that inputs and output markets are within farmers' reach.

- Increase farmers' access to inputs by creating retail outlets in rural areas.
- Enhance adoption of improved seed and other technologies.
- Strengthen links between rural retailers and large seed and input companies.
- Support the lobbying and advocacy capacity of input sellers.
- Create jobs and develop value chains, especially for youth and women.

Key activities: identifying and training agro-dealers (aiming for 40% women); linking input suppliers, agro-dealers and farmers; facilitating supply and value chain financing; running demand-stimulating activities for improved seed and technologies; and forming and strengthening business associations.

2. Model agro-dealer shops

Developing model shops as centres of excellence for training agro-dealers and encouraging good practice to be copied, with strong links to private-sector seed, agro-chemical and fertiliser companies.

3. Business development and consultancy services

Offering consultancy services that draw on our in-house and external expertise in agribusiness and rural enterprise development.

4. Nutrition and climate adaptation

Nutrition. Maize dominates production and diets, while legumes, oilseeds and vegetables get less attention. We promote diversified production to close seasonal food gaps: green leafy and orange vegetables, vitamin-fortified staples such as orange-fleshed sweet potato and orange maize, and legumes and nuts such as beans, soya, cowpeas, pigeon peas and groundnuts. Crop diversification, irrigation and better storage and use at household level all help.

Climate change. Access to appropriate, affordable inputs is a key way farmers adapt. Well-trained agro-dealers stock short-season and water-efficient varieties and legume seed, give advice at the point of sale and mount demonstration plots, helping farmers choose varieties suited to shorter and less predictable seasons.

How we track progress

- Better data-collection tools and a computerised database of agro-dealers, producing regular reports.
- Weekly staff meetings and quarterly management and board reviews.
- An open day at the mid-point, bringing together agro-dealer associations, suppliers, government, donors, staff and board members.
- Baselines in the first year, then a mid-term and end-of-plan evaluation led by an external consultant.
- Quarterly and annual reports, and case studies of the most significant community change.

Implementing partners

Ministry of Agriculture; Ministry of Livestock; Zambia Agriculture Research Institute (ZARI); MUSIKA Zambia; COMESA/ACTESA; Zambia Seed Traders Association; Women in Agribusiness in Southern Africa (WASA); Zambia Development Agency; CropLife Zambia; Fertilizer Association of Zambia; Zambia Environmental Management Agency; Agri Business Forum; and others.